Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Topic 5.4A Guided Notes: Neurodevelopmental, Psychotic, and Mood Disorders

Unit 5: Mental and Physical Health | AP Psychology

Directions: Read through the topic overview page below and fill in each blank as you go. Use the tables and activities to check your understanding, then head to the quiz link at the end to test yourself.

Source page: appsychreviewhub.com/overviews/topic5.4

Word Bank

Hallucinations	*Catatonic Stupor*	*Word Salad*
Neurodevelopmental Disorders	*Delusions of Grandeur*	*Delusions of Persecution*
Dopamine Hypothesis	*Schizophrenic Spectrum Disorders*	*Positive Symptoms*
Attention-Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD)	*Disorganized Speech*	*Acute*
Flat Affect	*Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD)*	*Catatonia*
Exclusion Statement	*Delusions*	*Chronic*
Negative Symptoms		

Topic 5.4 is the biggest topic in AP Psychology, so it is split into three guides: 5.4A (Sections 1–4), 5.4B (Sections 5–8), and 5.4C (Sections 9–10). Section numbers match the study guide page.

Welcome to the longest and most comprehensive topic in the entire AP Psychology curriculum! In this section, we move from general diagnostic frameworks into the explicit, clinical definitions of various mental conditions. While diagnostic manuals contain hundreds of conditions, the College Board establishes an explicit _____: the AP Psychology Exam focuses strictly on a designated representative subset of disorders to ensure an introductory understanding of psychopathology. Mastering this section requires deep familiarity with the distinct physiological, cognitive, and behavioral markers that separate these diagnostic clusters.

1. Neurodevelopmental Disorders

_____ constitute a specific cluster of conditions that begin during childhood and involve impairments in cognitive, behavioral, social, or motor functioning due to atypical brain development. Because these disorders manifest early in life, clinical symptoms focus on whether the person is exhibiting behaviors appropriate for their age or maturity range. Research indicates that their root causes are multifaceted, spanning environmental toxins, atypical physiological growth, or distinct genetic variations.

- _____: A condition characterized by persistent patterns of inattention, hyperactivity, and impulsivity that interfere with daily functioning or development. Individuals often struggle with executive dysfunction, staying organized, tracking details, or regulating motor activity.
- _____: A complex condition characterized by persistent difficulties in social communication and interaction across multiple contexts, along with restricted or repetitive patterns of

behavior, interests, or activities. This can include hyper-fixated interests, rigorous adherence to rigid routines, or atypical sensory processing.

Apply It: Which Neurodevelopmental Disorder?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A fourth grader constantly loses his homework, cannot stay seated, blurts out answers, and has trouble following multi-step directions, patterns that have been present for years and interfere with school.	
2	A teen has persistent trouble reading social cues at school and at home, becomes very upset when the lunch routine changes, and is intensely absorbed in memorizing weather data.	

2. Schizophrenic Spectrum Disorders

_____ represent a profound group of related psychotic disorders characterized by severe disruptions in thinking, perception, emotions, and behavior. Clinicians observe clinical manifestations across five primary domains, which are covered below. Schizophrenia itself can emerge dynamically; it may present as an _____ condition (developing suddenly in response to environmental stressors) or as a _____ condition (unfolding gradually over years with a prolonged course of recovery).

The primary biological explanation for these conditions is the _____, a long-standing theory suggesting that schizophrenia and related psychotic symptoms are explicitly associated with excessive activity of one specific neurotransmitter, or heightened receptor sensitivity, within certain brain pathways. Additional biological explanations point to prenatal virus exposure during maternal pregnancy, genetic vulnerabilities, or structural brain abnormalities.

Positive Symptoms: Manifestations of Excess

In psychopathology, _____ do not mean “good”—they refer to symptoms that involve the presence of abnormal experiences or behaviors that are added to a person's psychological reality. They reflect an excess or distortion of normal functioning.

- _____: Strongly held false beliefs that persist rigidly despite clear, undeniable evidence to the contrary. Two common types are:
- _____: False beliefs that one is actively being plotted against, harmed, harassed, or targeted by malicious outside forces, organizations, or individuals.
- _____: False beliefs in which a person thinks they possess exceptional power, infinite wealth, cosmic importance, historical fame, or a unique divine identity unsupported by reality.
- _____: False sensory experiences that occur entirely in the absence of an external physical stimulus. While these can involve any of the five senses (such as feeling phantom bugs or seeing unexplainable shapes), auditory experiences—such as hearing disembodied internal or external voices—remain the most common manifestation.
- _____: A cognitive symptom involving incoherent, illogical, or fragmented speech patterns that make it incredibly difficult for others to comprehend the person's train of thought. In its most extreme

clinical form, this collapses into a _____, where words, phrases, and random fragments are strung together in completely nonsensical, unintelligible arrays.

Apply It: Which Positive Symptom?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A woman insists she is a famous historical queen with infinite wealth, even though her family shows her records that prove otherwise.	
2	A man rigidly believes his coworkers have secretly replaced his family with imposters, and he refuses to change his mind despite clear proof.	
3	A student hears a voice insulting her when nobody is in the room and no sound is actually occurring.	
4	A man's explanations jump illogically from topic to topic, so listeners cannot follow his train of thought.	
5	A patient's speech has become so jumbled that it comes out as a string of unrelated words and fragments that no one can follow.	

Negative Symptoms & Motor Distortions: Manifestations of Deficit

Conversely, _____ involve a severe reduction, deficit, or complete loss of typical behaviors or typical emotional functioning that should normally be present.

- _____: A prominent symptom characterized by little to no outward expression of internal emotion. An individual exhibits a completely immobile face, a monotonous voice, and an absence of expressive physical gestures.
- _____ & Disorganized Motor Behavior: Highly abnormal movements that vary drastically. This can manifest as excitement (frenzied, purposeless overactivity) or collapse completely into a _____. In this state, an individual is completely immobile, unresponsive, and mute, appearing awake but failing to react to any external stimuli in their environment.

Apply It: Course, Causes, and Negative Symptoms

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A researcher links a patient's psychotic symptoms to overactive receptors for one particular brain chemical.	
2	A young man's psychotic symptoms appear within days after a major stressor.	
3	A woman's symptoms unfold slowly over many years, with a long course of recovery.	
4	A man's emotional life seems to have shrunk; he has lost the ability to show typical feelings, expression, or motivation.	
5	A man tells his family a joyful story about winning a prize in a monotone voice, with a motionless face and no gestures.	

#	Scenario	Concept
6	A patient alternates between frantic, purposeless pacing and stretches of near-total stillness.	

📺 *Video Notes: "Schizophrenia and Dissociative Disorders" (Crash Course Psychology #32)*

This video covers schizophrenia and also dissociative disorders. For this guide, watch from the start to about 8:05, which is the schizophrenia part. The dissociative disorders section (about 8:05 to the end) goes with Section 7, which is in Guide 5.4B. Answer each question below in your own words.

1. What does the word "schizophrenia" literally mean, what misconception does the video correct, and how common is the disorder?

2. How does the video say the DSM-5 describes the schizophrenia spectrum, and what are psychotic symptoms?

3. How does the video describe disorganized thinking and speech, and what kinds of delusions does it name?

4. What does the video say about hallucinations and incongruent emotions or behaviors?

5. What are the three categories of psychotic symptoms in the video, and what brain abnormalities does it connect to schizophrenia?

6. How does the video explain the diathesis-stress model, and what does it say about genetic risk?

Word Bank

Persistent Depressive Disorder	*Hypomania*	*Depressive Disorders*
Bipolar I Disorder	*Bipolar Disorders*	*Major Depressive Disorder*
Cycling	*Bipolar II Disorder*	*Mania*

3. Depressive Disorders

_____ are a group of mood disorders characterized by the presence of a sad, empty, or irritable mood, paired alongside structural physical and cognitive changes that significantly impair a person's basic ability to function. Etiology is multi-causal, with research focusing on biological imbalances (such as serotonin depletion), genetic predispositions, traumatic social environments, cultural expectations, behavioral learned helplessness, or maladaptive cognitive patterns.

- _____: A severe form characterized by a persistent depressed mood or a profound loss of interest or pleasure in nearly all activities (anhedonia), along with additional symptoms like sleep disruptions, fatigue, and worthlessness, lasting continuously for at least two weeks.
- _____: A chronic, low-grade form of depression characterized by a depressed mood lasting for most of the day, for more days than not, for a minimum of two consecutive years. Though less acute than the severe form, its long duration heavily wears down an individual's resilience.

Apply It: Which Depressive Disorder?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	For the past month, a man has felt hopeless, has lost interest in everything he used to enjoy, cannot sleep, and feels worthless nearly every day.	
2	A woman has felt down, tired, and low on self-worth on most days for the past three years, though she still manages her basic responsibilities.	

4. Bipolar Disorders

_____ are distinctive mood conditions characterized by dramatic shifts in energy and activity, specifically marked by alternating periods of extremely elevated energy and periods of depression. This cyclical movement is known as _____, describing the pattern of shifting between emotional extremes over various lengths of time. Its causes are multi-causal, drawing on biological and genetic vulnerabilities, but also shaped by social and cultural stressors, learned behavioral patterns, and maladaptive cognitive interpretations of mood shifts.

- _____: A state of abnormally elevated, expansive, or irritable mood, accompanied by surging energy and activity levels. During a manic episode, individuals experience a decreased need for sleep, rapid flight of ideas, intense impulsivity, and severely impaired judgment that disrupts daily life.
- _____: Characterized by the experience of at least one full manic episode. These intense episodes often result in severe behavioral consequences and may be preceded or followed by milder elevated episodes or major depressive episodes.

- _____: Characterized by a clinical history of at least one major depressive episode and at least one _____ episode. This is a period of elevated mood, increased energy, and heightened activity that is distinctly less severe than full mania; it does not cause severe impairment in daily functioning, nor does it require clinical hospitalization. Bipolar II never contains a full manic episode.

Apply It: Which Bipolar Concept?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	Over the past year, a woman has swung from weeks of very high energy and little need for sleep to weeks of deep depression, and back again.	
2	A man tells everyone he is about to become a billionaire, has not slept in days, and starts five major projects in one afternoon, all with poor judgment.	
3	For four days, a woman feels unusually energetic, confident, and productive, but her work and relationships stay on track and she needs no hospital care.	
4	After a week of extreme elation and reckless behavior that ended in an emergency hospital stay, a teen later falls into a long depression.	
5	A woman has had one major depressive episode and several milder stretches of high energy that never disrupted her work or required hospitalization.	

📺 *Video Notes: "Depressive and Bipolar Disorders" (Crash Course Psychology #30)*

Watch the video above, then answer each question below in your own words. The video also covers causes (genes, brain chemistry, and thinking patterns) that go beyond what's on the page, and it uses the term "mood disorders" for both depressive and bipolar disorders.

1. How does the video define a mood, how are moods different from emotions, and what two kinds of mood disorders does it name?

2. How does the video separate normal sadness from depressive disorders, and how does the DSM-5 diagnose major depressive disorder?

3. How does the video describe bipolar disorder and mania?

4. According to the video, what roles do genes, environment, and gender play in mood disorders?

5. How does the video describe the brain and the social-cognitive perspective on mood disorders?

Don't Trip Up! (Common Misconceptions)

⚠️ Bipolar I vs. Bipolar II: Remember, _____ requires at least one full manic episode (extreme, high-stakes behavior, potential hospitalization). _____ requires a milder hypomanic episode alongside a major depressive episode. If a scenario describes full mania, it is automatically _____.

Quick Check: Review Questions

Circle the best answer for each question below.

1. A young child has significant difficulty communicating and interacting with other children socially, becomes extremely distressed by even minor changes to his daily routine, and shows an intense, narrow fixation on organizing his toy trains by color for hours at a time. This neurodevelopmental condition is called:

- **A.** Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD)
- **B.** Persistent Depressive Disorder
- **C.** ADHD
- **D.** Schizophrenia

2. A man firmly and unshakably believes that government agents have secretly implanted a tracking device in his brain and are constantly monitoring his every move, despite overwhelming evidence proving this is not true. This symptom, a false belief of being targeted by outside forces, is called a:

- **A.** Hallucination
- **B.** Flat Affect
- **C.** Delusion of Persecution
- **D.** Delusion of Grandeur

3. A patient with schizophrenia is found completely motionless and unresponsive, appearing awake with his eyes open but failing to react in any way to being spoken to, touched, or moved by hospital staff. This severe motor symptom, involving complete immobility and unresponsiveness, is called:

- **A.** Catatonic Stupor
- **B.** A Hallucination
- **C.** Catatonic Excitement
- **D.** Flat Affect

4. For the past three weeks, a woman has experienced a persistently depressed mood, a complete loss of interest in hobbies she once loved, disrupted sleep, constant fatigue, and pervasive feelings of worthlessness nearly every day. This severe depressive disorder is called:

- **A.** Persistent Depressive Disorder
- **B.** Generalized Anxiety Disorder
- **C.** Bipolar I Disorder
- **D.** Major Depressive Disorder

5. During a specific episode, a man requires almost no sleep for several days, talks rapidly with racing, disorganized ideas, spends his entire life savings on an impulsive business scheme, and shows severely impaired judgment that disrupts his daily life. This state of abnormally elevated mood and energy is called:

- **A.** Dissociative Amnesia
- **B.** Mania
- **C.** Persistent Depressive Disorder
- **D.** Hypomania

6. A woman has a documented clinical history of at least one full manic episode requiring hospitalization, during which she experienced severe impulsivity and impaired judgment, along with subsequent depressive episodes. This diagnosis is:

- **A.** Major Depressive Disorder
- **B.** Bipolar II Disorder
- **C.** Generalized Anxiety Disorder
- **D.** Bipolar I Disorder

7. A man has a clinical history of at least one major depressive episode along with a period of noticeably elevated mood and energy that never became severe enough to require hospitalization or cause major impairment in his daily functioning. This diagnosis is:

- **A.** Panic Disorder
- **B.** Major Depressive Disorder Alone
- **C.** Bipolar II Disorder
- **D.** Bipolar I Disorder

✅ Check Your Progress

Done with your notes? Head over to the Quiz to test what you've learned:
https://appsychreviewhub.com/quiz

Source content adapted from Psych Review Hub — Topic 5.4A: Selection of Categories of Psychological Disorders (Neurodevelopmental, Psychotic, and Mood Disorders) (appsychreviewhub.com)